ELEMENTS OF EFFECTIVE PRACTICE FOR MENTORING™

ELEMENT 5

YOUTH ENROLLMENT

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PRACTICES SUPPORTING THIS STANDARD

- ***The program has established policies and procedures for confirming youth eligibility and their compatibility with, and interest in, the services offered, and for accepting or not accepting them into the program.*** All mentoring programs need a standardized set of policies and accompanying procedures that manage the process of determining eligibility and accepting new mentees into the program, including ensuring that participants understand both the benefits of participation and their roles and responsibilities and that they are interested in, and committed to, being a part of the program.

- ***The program provides youth (and caregivers, as needed) with a formal application that is completed as part of the enrollment process.*** The questions in the application can help programs collect information on youth's strengths, areas for growth, goals for the mentoring experience, desired traits in a mentor, and important personal characteristics (such as their background, special needs, hobbies, and interests) that can help programs find the right mentor (or group) to maximize the impact of their participation. This information must be stored securely and managed with confidentiality, and staff should be equipped to respond appropriately when sensitive information is shared (e.g., LGBTQIA2S+ status, disability-related information).

- ***Youth (and their caregivers, as needed) formally consent to participate in the program and commit to following program expectations and rules upon their acceptance into the program.*** This commitment should include understanding and agreeing to program policies, particularly regarding safety, as well as details around the frequency of mentoring meetings and the duration of the mentoring relationship. For many programs, this will be roughly once a week for the duration of a school or calendar year, although that will depend on the program's design and theory of change. As part of the consent process, the program should also provide an estimated timeline for when the mentee will be matched with a mentor.

Additional Practices for Consideration

- ***As appropriate, the program asks caregivers to provide additional information, beyond the application, that will help determine eligibility and fit and identify an appropriate mentor (or mentoring group) for the young person.*** Additional information can be gathered in several ways, for example, through interviews, conversations, or additional forms. This practice can also identify other adults, beyond the youth's caregiver, who can support their involvement in the program or who may need to inform decisions about the relationship.
- ***The program refers youth who have needs or circumstances beyond the program's scope to other services and supports in the community, especially when youth are ineligible to participate in the program.*** Programs should have a list of referral partners — both other mentoring programs as well as other types of service providers — for youth and families who are not accepted into the program.

ADDITIONAL RECOMMENDATIONS FOR COMMON PROGRAM MODELS AND SETTINGS

Because there is tremendous diversity in how and where mentoring is delivered to young people, we also offer additional practices and recommendations related to this Element for the following program models and contexts. Readers should note that there may be overlap in the following categories (e.g., a peer mentoring program in a school or a Boys & Girls Club offering a group mentoring program on-site) and read all that may be relevant to their work. The next recommendations can help navigate the nuances of the early stages of working with mentees and those supporting their mentoring experience.

GROUP MENTORING MODELS

In addition to the general practices noted above, group mentoring programs may need to consider whether all enrollment needs to happen in a predetermined timeframe so that there are enough participants available to form groups. This will facilitate forming groups that will have membership stability from the beginning and will not need to add new members sporadically throughout the year. The application and other enrollment activities should also gather information about peer relationships with other youth in the program to avoid placing those with negative prior histories in the same group.

Group models will also need to consider whether a group experience is the right fit for a particular young person. Some youth may simply benefit more from a deeper one-to-one relationship with a mentor, while others may have personality traits (e.g., extreme shyness) or behavioral challenges that may be problematic in a group setting. Youth who are not the right fit can be referred to other programs or services as needed.

PEER MENTORING MODELS

Given that many cross-age peer mentoring programs serve relatively young mentees (i.e., elementary school age) there may be a need to engage caregivers more in the application and enrollment processes to solicit information about the youth and why participation in the program may be beneficial. Programs may also need to explain the goals of the program and what participation will be like for younger mentees.

E-MENTORING MODELS

E-mentoring programs face some additional challenges enrolling youth due to the virtual nature of the communication between program staff and youth and their caregivers. These programs should prioritize online applications and other easy-to-use digital forms, supplemented with face-to-face conversations using virtual meeting technology so that details about the program can be explained and questions and concerns can be addressed in real time.

The enrollment process is also an ideal time to assess the youth's technology access, comfort, and skill in using technology, and developmental suitability to communicate using virtual platforms (especially for very young children). Some youth may lack the requisite technology access or comfort to participate meaningfully in the program. If the program will make technology available to participants, that should also be explained during the enrollment process.

It is also important to share policies and other information about program safety, privacy, confidentiality, and data management with young people (and caregivers, as relevant) as they enroll in the program. They should understand what program staff can access about their mentoring interactions and other monitoring policies or practices. Programs may also clarify expectations for privacy for online mentoring conversations, including whether caregivers or others (e.g., siblings) are allowed or encouraged to join or overhear mentoring conversations.

E-mentoring programs should also get consent from caregivers around the collection of electronic data about the youth's participation (e.g., accessing chat or emails sent to the mentor, tracking engagement in an online mentoring platform, monitoring for risk management concerns, etc.). Youth should also understand exactly what components of their interactions are shared with program staff and how that information will be used. See the *E-Mentoring Supplement to the Elements of Effective Practice for Mentoring™*, fourth edition, for more information about youth data privacy, consent, and legal obligations regarding youth participation in online programs (Garringer et al. 2019).

SCHOOL- AND OTHER FORMAL SITE-BASED MODELS

Schools and other youth-serving organizations may already have policies and procedures in place for how youth sign up for specific supports, such as mentoring or tutoring. The program's enrollment process should align with any existing site procedures. The enrollment process is also an ideal time to assess any scheduling conflicts (e.g., conflicts with class schedules or other school activities) that may impact youth's participation in mentoring activities.

Enrollment is also an ideal time to ensure that youth understand the purpose of the mentoring program and how it is distinct from other services they may have access to.

INFORMAL MENTORING MODELS

Informal mentoring, almost by definition, implies that youth aren't formally being accepted into a mentoring program. However, there may still be "eligibility" criteria for consideration. For example, in a program serving high school age youth, informal mentoring may be prioritized for those graduating high school in the next year to support their transitions into college or career paths. Informal mentoring can still have some focused outreach if staff capacity is limited.

DISCUSSION OF THIS ELEMENT

Youth enrollment processes will likely differ across program models and contexts. For example, community-based programs will likely involve caregivers in these processes to a much greater extent than site-based programs. However, **all programs, regardless of program model, should have written policies and procedures in place to guide the entire youth enrollment process. Enrollment should include:**

- assessing youth eligibility, interest in, and compatibility with the services offered;
- discussing the youth's (and when relevant, their caregiver's) motivations and goals for participating;
- gathering information about the youth that can be used to find a suitable mentor (and group, if relevant) and support them in their mentoring experience;
- highlighting expectations and requirements for participants;
- documenting their agreement to these expectations;
- formally accepting, or not accepting, each young person into the program, including formal consent by the youth and caregiver; and
- referring youth to other services when needed.

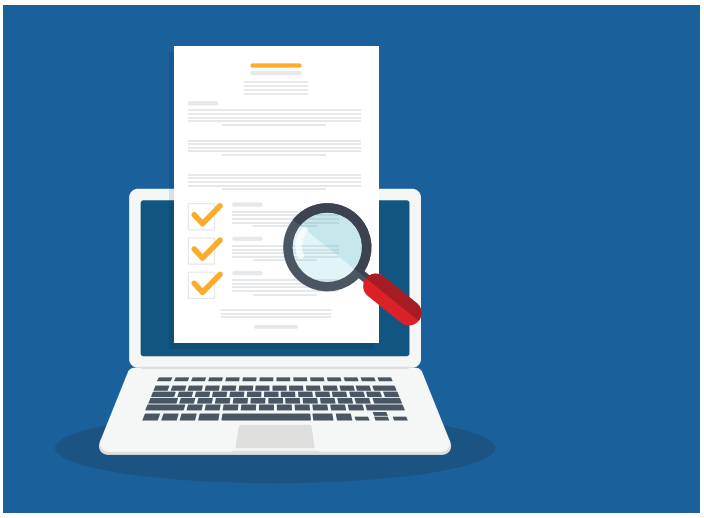
These processes should help ensure that participants understand both the benefits of participation and their responsibilities in contributing to the mentoring relationship and confirm their interest and commitment to being part of the program. These procedures should be streamlined and completed in a timely manner to avoid potential participants losing interest.

Collecting Key Information

One of the most important aspects of offering a young person the right mentoring support is gathering relevant information about them (and their family, when pertinent) during program enrollment. **The program should collect this information through a formal application.** The application should include questions about the youth's demographics, including race, gender identity, primary language, and other aspects of their background (all of which can help your program document who you are reaching), why they want to participate in the program, and their goals for involvement. It may be important to also identify other adults in the young person's life who may need to be involved in facilitating the relationship or engaged in program communications (e.g., extended kin, legal guardians, other "champions" in their life). Programs are also encouraged, as appropriate, to ask caregivers or other referring individuals to provide additional information about why the youth might benefit from mentoring and special considerations staff and mentors should be aware of.

Setting expectations around how long it may take to get matched and the chances of not finding an appropriate mentor for the child is also important...

In addition, **the program should gather information about characteristics of the youth that can be helpful in finding a suitable mentor.** Especially relevant is information about special needs, hobbies, interests, strengths, and areas for growth, including the goals they may have for the relationship and a



mentor's support. This information can be gathered through the application or through interviews, conversations, or additional forms, and can help you find the best mentor for each youth. Although some studies suggest that matching on characteristics like race, gender, or disability status can be beneficial (see for example, Lyons & Edwards, 2022; Heppe et al., 2020; Oberoi, 2016; Raposa et al., 2019), other studies do not support these associations (e.g., Heppe et al., 2021; Kanchewa et al., 2014; Kern et al., 2019). Research is more consistent on the value of matching based on characteristics like shared interests, attitudes, values, beliefs, hobbies, talents, identities, and personality (see Deng et al., 2022). Thus, collecting information on these characteristics during enrollment can help you make strong, effective matches. (For more discussion on matching, see Element 9.)

Because the relevance of specific youth characteristics and experiences will differ across programs, it is important to think about your theory of change and what kinds of matches would be most likely to yield the outcomes of interest to your program — and to craft your application and other procedures to collect and document this information. Once collected, this information can be helpful in creating a "profile" of participating youth that can provide their prospective mentor with a rich, strengths-based description of the person with whom they will be developing a relationship.

Information gathered in the application and other enrollment activities must be managed with confidentiality, and staff should be equipped to respond appropriately when sensitive information is shared (e.g., LGBTQIA2S+ status, disability-related information). In some cases, staff may need to consider legal requirements in their state around how such information is managed and who they may be required to share it with. (See Element 15 for more details on information management and privacy.) In fact, programs may decide to omit some questions from their applications or data from participant records if they are required to share information that could place youth in harm's way, due to recent changes in state or local laws (e.g., laws around the legality of gender-affirming care). This is an area where the program's ethical values should guide policy and practice.

Ensuring that All Are on the Same Page

Because caregivers complete the application for many programs, an additional conversation with the young person can be helpful to ensure that youth see value in the program and want to participate. Youth who are excited about the program and how a mentor can support them are more likely to sustain the match and benefit from the relationship. Thus, If the program is voluntary and the mentee was referred by a caregiver, the program should directly ask the young person to confirm their interest in receiving a mentor. This should be done with the caregiver's permission and can be as brief as asking them to confirm that they understand what a mentor is and that they are interested. These

conversations can also help ensure that caregiver and youth goals for the experience are aligned and that youth understand program requirements and expectations.

Creating this shared understanding from the beginning is an important step in starting a meaningful mentoring experience. Unmet expectations for program involvement can lead caregivers to end the mentoring relationship prematurely (Shamblen et al., 2020). Making sure youth also have realistic expectations for their involvement is similarly important; when youth expectations are not met, the match may also struggle (Spencer, 2007). Setting expectations around how long it may take to get matched and the chances of not finding an appropriate mentor for the child is also important. This timeline can be broad, but programs are encouraged to "under-promise and over-deliver" to prevent disappointment and should provide an update if the timeline needs to be extended. Youth who are not matched, or who are not matched as quickly as expected, may see this as indicating something negative about themselves. In fact, recent research suggests not matching a child who expects to get matched can be associated with setbacks in the very outcomes the program may be trying to foster (Lindstrom Johnson et al., 2022).

Signing a Formal Agreement

A formal consent form should be signed by the young person and their legal guardian to show they agree to participate in the program and understand its requirements. When youth join your program, it is important that they formally commit to the program's expectations for participation and the rules that govern participant behavior. Families should understand program rules — for example where, when, and how often matches are allowed to meet, and should commit to those rules in writing. Using the enrollment process to explain program rules and how they support a safe, effective mentoring relationship can help ensure they are upheld. As noted, it is especially important that youth consent to the experience. Ideally, this commitment to follow program rules and expectations will be documented in writing once they are officially accepted into the program.

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Determining Who Is Not a Good Fit for Your Program

Collecting detailed information about youth and their family can also highlight ways they might not be a good candidate for your program or may have needs that are beyond what your mentors can reasonably address. In some cases, youth are simply ineligible because they are too young or old for the program or they don't live in the program's service area. Other criteria can be more challenging to determine. For example, a program may determine that a youth's lack of enthusiasm for the program leaves them unlikely to have a positive experience, or that the needs their family is hoping mentoring can alleviate are beyond the scope and capacity of the program to address adequately (e.g., serious mental health or behavioral challenges). Yet, this decision is a critical step in the enrollment process. Determining who is "out of scope" for your program can help your staff target your services to those youth who could benefit the most and, at the same time, ensure mentors are not faced with situations they feel ill-equipped to handle.

Research to date has not indicated that any particular youth characteristics or experiences are important to "screen out" — this determination is very much dependent on your program's mission and theory of change. But research has begun to outline the types of youth experiences and behaviors associated with matches that may struggle. Importantly, it also highlights the interplay between youth characteristics, mentor characteristics and program supports. For example, one study (Raposa et al., 2016) found that youth who had experienced more significant environmental stressors (e.g., parental incarceration, losing someone of import to the child, a recent parent separation) had shorter matches than those experiencing fewer; whereas youth with more behavioral challenges (i.e., misconduct, substance use, academic struggles) had lower relationship quality than youth with fewer. However, mentors' level of involvement with youth prior to mentoring buffered both these associations, indicating that the program could support youth with more serious challenges provided they had the right mentors in place. Another study (Weiler et al., 2019) found similar associations between exposure to environmental stressors and relationship quality. These associations, however, were lessened when mentors had positive program experiences including perceptions of adequate program structure, supportive program relationships, and opportunities for skill building. These studies highlight the importance of considering your programmatic context — the mentors you are engaging and the supports you have in place — to determine which youth might and might not be a good fit for your program.

Once you have determined that a young person is not a good fit for your program, the youth (and caregiver when relevant) should be notified of your decision using a method of communication that reflects how you have interacted with them throughout the enrollment process (e.g., in writing if you have only communicated in writing; in writing and by phone if you have met them in person, etc.). This communication should explain why they were not a good fit for the program in ways that avoid blame or judgment. **We also recommend putting mechanisms in place to refer them to other services.** Mechanisms for these referrals include establishing and fostering community partnerships, documenting eligibility requirements for these organizations, and creating a regularly updated list of these organizations that is accessible to enrollment staff.

QUESTIONS FOR PROGRAM STAFF TO CONSIDER

- **What information do we need to collect to get to know and best serve our youth and families?**
- **Do we ask about youth strengths, goals, and dreams in addition to asking about needs or difficult circumstances? Are we building on assets and strengths or focusing only on challenges?**
- **How will we ensure that youth (and caregivers) commit to the expectations for program participation that we set? Are there certain levels of participation that we will require?**
- **What might disqualify a youth from being accepted into our program? Are there needs or circumstances we feel are beyond our mentors' ability to address? Do we have clear criteria for making these determinations?**
- **Where can we refer youth and families in our community when they are ineligible or not a good fit for what we offer?**

OPPORTUNITIES FOR AUTHENTIC YOUTH AND COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT

- **Youth and caregivers may have feedback on the enrollment process, including their ease and comfort level completing application forms and other required paperwork, and can share their perceptions of enrollment activities, such as conversations with staff and the overall timeline and flow of the enrollment process.**

Potential Metrics to Track

Programs may want to set benchmarks and track progress around metrics such as:

- **The percentage of youth applicants that are accepted into the program, not accepted, or quit the enrollment process (with analysis of the demographic composition of each group and the reasons for disengagement or not being accepted).**
- **The average length of time it takes an applicant to get accepted into the program.**
- **The percentage of applicants that completed all enrollment procedures.**
- **The number and nature of referrals to other service providers for youth who are not accepted into the program.**
- **The number and nature of community partnerships supporting those referrals.**

RESOURCES THAT CAN HELP

Foundations of Successful Youth Mentoring: Effective Strategies for Providing Quality Youth Mentoring in Schools and Communities. Garringer, M., MacRae, P., National Mentoring Center and The Hamilton Fish Institute on School and Community Violence. This guidebook for program development offers research-informed guidance, tools, and resources to support quality mentoring services.

"Mentee Readiness" Module from Shining Light on the Commercial Sexual Exploitation of Children: A Toolkit to Build Understanding. Youth Collaboratory. This module, 1 of 19, discusses the importance of assessing mentee readiness in preparing them to begin a mentoring relationship.

Risk Management and Youth Safety Components for Mentoring and Youth-Serving Programs. MENTOR, National Mentoring Resource Center. This brief discusses risk management for mentoring programs including screening of both mentors and mentees.

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